“What Does She Actually Need?” Eight Questions Families Ask Before Comparing Care Settings

Plain answers to the general questions, and a note on which ones belong to her care team.

There are questions you may not have wanted to ask the social worker in the hallway. Most families in your place have the same ones. Here are eight of them.

The answers are general. Several of the questions are really about your wife, and for those the plain answer is who to ask.

1 What's the difference between assisted living, memory care and a nursing home?

In general terms: the National Institute on Aging describes assisted living as for people who need help with daily care, but not as much help as a nursing home provides, and nursing homes, also called skilled nursing facilities, as providing a wide range of health and personal care services. The Family Caregiver Alliance describes memory care as specialized care for people with cognitive impairments, in a free-standing residence or as part of an assisted living facility. Those describe kinds of places. They don't say which one fits a particular person. [1] [2]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you'd like to know why one of those names came up for your wife. Ask the social worker what they've found she needs that led to it.

2 If two places are both called assisted living, do they offer the same help?

Not necessarily. The National Institute on Aging says exact arrangements vary by facility and by state. The Family Caregiver Alliance says each state has different regulations for what is and is not provided, and that service can vary greatly. The name tells you the kind of place. What a particular place does is something to ask it. [1] [2]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you aren't sure what to ask a particular place to confirm. Her care team can tell you which of her needs to raise.

3 What help has to be available for her?

That list starts with you. Write each task your wife gets help with, what kind of help it is, and when you've seen it needed. The Family Caregiver Alliance's discharge guide lists the usual areas: bathing, dressing, eating, personal hygiene, grooming, toileting, moving from bed to chair, walking, medications and more. What has to be available in her next arrangement is settled when her care team goes over your list and adds what they've found. [3]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you've written down the help you give and want to know what isn't on it yet. Ask the nurse or therapist who has been working with her.

4 How do we tell what's essential from what would just be nice?

Keep two lists. The National Institute on Aging asks the two questions separately: what services are needed, and what features are important to the person, such as meals, social and recreational activities, a religious connection, or staying close to family and friends. Ask your wife about the second list and write her answers in her words. The Family Caregiver Alliance notes that there is no such thing as a “perfect” placement, but you can make a decision that meets as many of your priorities as possible. [4] [5]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** an item about her health, her medications or how much watching over she needs could go on either list. Put it on a “not sure” list and let her care team place it.

5 What needs to be confirmed before we choose?

Anything you'd otherwise be guessing. On this roadmap that means how often she needs a kind of help when you haven't seen it yourself, any question about supervision, and the nursing or therapy her care team says she needs. Write each one as a question, with the name of who answers it. The National Institute on Aging's advice when you're unsure is to ask a health care provider which services may be most helpful. [4]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you find you've been filling a gap with a guess. Write it as a question and take it to her doctor, her nurse or her therapist.

6 Who decides what level of care she needs?

It takes the professionals who assess her, working with what you and she tell them. The Family Caregiver Alliance describes discharge planning as a process that determines the kind of care a patient needs after leaving the hospital. It begins with an evaluation of the patient by qualified personnel and a discussion with the patient or her representative, and the planner will look to you for history and insights. It isn't settled by a family alone, or by a page like this one. [3]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** a setting is being talked about and you don't know what assessment it rests on. Ask who assessed her, and what they found.

7 I do most of her care myself. Does what I can keep doing come into it?

Yes. The Family Caregiver Alliance says discharge planners should discuss with you your willingness and ability to provide care, and that you should tell them about any limits you have. Its guide to choosing a place says to keep your own needs in mind as well as hers. Write down what you do now and what you can realistically keep doing. It's information the plan needs, and it says nothing about how much you care. [3] [5]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you're unsure whether you can keep doing something you do now. Say so to the discharge staff.

8 This is moving quickly. Can we ask for more time?

You can ask. The Family Caregiver Alliance's discharge guide says that if you're feeling hurried, it is reasonable to ask the discharge planning team to slow things down so nothing is overlooked. We can't tell you what the answer will be. Having your list and your questions written down helps you say exactly what still needs settling. [3]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you don't know who to raise it with. Start with the social worker or the discharge planner.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't answer any question about your wife herself. What kind of care she needs, how much help, and which setting fits are for the professionals who assess her.

Ready for the next step?

You have plain answers to the general questions, and you know which ones belong to her care team. The care interview is where the questions become about your wife: it goes through her daily life area by area and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. National Institute on Aging, Long-Term Care Facilities: Assisted Living, Nursing Homes, and Other Residential Care
2. Family Caregiver Alliance, Residential Care Options: Housing Options
3. Family Caregiver Alliance, Hospital Discharge Planning: A Guide for Families and Caregivers
4. National Institute on Aging, How To Choose a Nursing Home or Other Long-Term Care Facility
5. Family Caregiver Alliance, Residential Care Options: Choosing the Right Place

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